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ENGL 225 Shakespeare: Beyond Tragedy

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Motherhood in *Richard II*

The Henriad is a story about men. William Shakespeare fills his stage with fathers, brothers, sons, and cousins. Sons inherit the land and grudges of their fathers—but what of their mothers? Compared to the plethora of father-son pairs, there are very few mothers in the first half of the Henriad. According to the Henriad men, especially in *Richard II*, men come from the earth: Gaunt calls English soil “This nurse, this teeming womb of royal kings” (*R2*, 2.1.56), Henry Bolingbroke addresses it as “My mother and my nurse that bears me yet” (1.3.314), and Richard has his own oddly ambiguous mother-child relationship with the earth (3.2.6-11). Where are the actual mothers? How do they feel, after dangerous pregnancies and endless childcare, about dirt taking the credit?

When the men do discuss their mothers, they objectify the women into blood donors and prune them from the family tree, as clearly demonstrated in *Henry V*. Henry Bolingbroke’s son Hal, newly crowned king of England, heeds his late father’s advice and seeks to unite England and “busy giddy minds / With foreign quarrels” (*2H4*, 4.3.372-373) by claiming France as his inheritance from his great-great-grandmother, Queen Isabella, a French princess. However, despite her importance, Queen Isabella is never named in Hal’s meetings; Hal is merely “claiming from the female” (*H5*, 1.2.97). One modern editor of *Henry V* claims, “Shakespeare assumes his audience’s familiarity with [the royal lineage] as [archbishop] Canterbury assumes Henry’s” (Taylor 102n (1.2.39)), so including her name would have been unnecessary. Indeed, the claim is introduced as “[d]erived from Edward, [Hal’s] great-grandfather” and accordingly

from Edward's mother (1.1.94). Yet Canterbury is allowed to prattle off a long, comedically boring recount of several lineages and laws that support Hal's claim. When so many useless details were included, why would the vital woman's name be redundant and cut for time? This absence erases Queen Isabella's personhood and objectifies her existence into the blood in Hal's veins, shielding his actions from criticism. Unlike her son and grandson, whose "warlike spirit" and military conquests are described in great detail (*H5*, 1.2.104), Queen Isabella is unseen, unheard, and unremembered beyond her duty of producing an heir.

However, a few generations down the line, and a few plays back, two women defy this standard of being ignored. In *Richard II*, the Queen of England and the Duchess of York's lives and identities are intertwined with the concept of being (or not-being) mothers, and they are treated by men as such. Although these women do not dramatically affect the main politics of the play, and could be viewed as passively and blindly supporting the men around them, the Queen and the Duchess strategically utilize the language of motherhood to gain power in their arguments with men.

The Queen in *Richard II*, like Queen Isabella, goes unnamed (though some editions assign her "Queen Isabel"). Her namelessness may have been practical or unintentional; Shakespeare had combined Richard's two real wives into one character (Dawson and Yachnin 132n), and royalty are typically addressed by honorifics. Regardless of its origin, the absence of a name detaches the Queen from the men around her, who tend to each have several names and titles. This absence complicates the perception of her as a person beyond her marriage. She is merely Richard's wife, the Queen of England; who cares who she is as a person? However, unlike Queen Isabella, this Queen appears on stage and has the autonomy to defend her opinions and livelihood.

The Queen, in Act 2 Scene 2 of *Richard II*, has a conversation with Richard's councilor Bushy, who dismisses her unease at Richard's absence during Henry Bolingbroke's banishment.

The Queen pushes back, arguing:

[...] Yet again methinks
 Some unborn sorrow ripe in Fortune's womb
 Is coming towards me, and my inward soul
 With nothing trembles. At some thing it grieves
 More than with parting from my lord the King.
 [...] Conceit is still derived
 From some forefather grief. Mine is not so,
 For nothing hath begot my something grief—
 Or something hath the nothing that I grieve.
 'Tis in reversion that I do possess,
 But what it is that is not yet known what,
 I cannot name. 'Tis nameless woe, I wot. (*R2*, 2.2.9-41)

Then, when councilor Green reveals that Bolingbroke is indeed rebelling, the Queen laments:

So, Green, thou art the midwife to my woe,
 And Bolingbroke my sorrow's dismal heir.
 Now hath my soul brought forth her prodigy,
 And I, a gasping new-delivered mother,
 Have woe to woe, sorrow to sorrow joined. (*R2*, 2.2.65-69)

In between these two excerpts, Bushy attempts to patronisingly explain how “perspectives” can be confusing (2.2.18), although he mixes up his details. The queen retaliates by committing further to her childbirth metaphor to reinforce that, just as women understand childbirth better than men, she understands her own unease better than Bushy does.

This birthing imagery is particularly interesting because Richard and the Queen never had children. This lack of an heir is an underlying conflict throughout *Richard II* that ultimately assigns Bolingbroke as Richard's pseudo-heir. The Queen's phrase, “my inward soul / With nothing trembles” (11-12), could be read as her mourning the children she never had, as she grieves “nothing” (38). Her placement as the “new-delivered mother” birthing woe (68) would then mirror her perceived responsibility for the misfortune of the country.

The underlying implication throughout the play that Richard is sleeping with Bushy and Green (3.1.8-15) complicates this claim and this scene. If this implication is true, does the queen know? Does she consent to it? If she does know at this scene, the line “nothing hath begot my something grief” (37) could be a hidden insult to Bushy. Just as Shakespeare used the term in *Hamlet*, “nothing” can be “a fair thought to lie between maids’ legs”, i.e. a lack of external genitalia (*Hamlet*, 3.2.125-127). Under this lens, the Queen implies that, even though she hasn’t had children, her womanly “nothing” makes her emotions and her connection to Richard stronger than whatever Bushy believes or feels.

The Duchess of York suffers similarly to the Queen. Just like the queens, the Duchess is unnamed. This is typical for Shakespeare’s duchesses and less important nobility, but it echoes the social norm to define women by their husbands. However, the Duchess does not restrict herself to the expectations of society, her husband, or the king. She throws herself into the spotlight when defending her son Aurmele, a conspirator against newly-crowned Bolingbroke at the end of *Richard II*. She first rebels against her husband, who insists on reporting Aurmele’s treason, and reminds him of their familial connections:

Have we more sons? Or are we like to have?
 Is not my teeming date drunk up with time?
 And wilt thou pluck my fair son from mine age
 And rob me of a happy mother’s name?
 [...]
 Hadst thou groaned for him as I have done,
 Thou wouldst be more pitiful. (*R2*, 5.2.89-114)

Here, the Duchess deliberately claims the title and position of a mother, reminding her husband both of her connection to their son and that, if Aurmele dies, she will have failed as a woman in this society. Like the Queen, she doesn’t have enough time left to give birth (The Queen’s deadline was the rebellion; the Duchess’ was menopause). She uses this fact to carve a

place for herself in this man-centric political conversation of treason and law. Then, in the next scene, the Duchess dares to not only interrupt the court proceedings of Aurmele and the Duke before King Henry Bolingbroke, but she repeatedly ignores the direct order of the king:

KING HENRY

Rise up, good aunt.

DUCHESS Not yet, I thee beseech.

[...]

KING HENRY

Good aunt, stand up.

DUCHESS Nay, do not say “stand up.”

Say “pardon” first and afterwards “stand up.”

An if I were thy nurse, thy tongue to teach,

“Pardon” should be the first word of thy speech.

[...]

KING HENRY

Good aunt, stand up.

DUCHESS I do not sue to stand.

Pardon is all the suit I have in hand.

KING HENRY

I pardon him, as God shall pardon me.

DUCHESS

O, happy vantage of a kneeling knee!

Yet am I sick for fear. Speak it again.

Twice saying “pardon” doth not pardon twain,

But makes one pardon strong.

KING HENRY I pardon him with all my heart.

DUCHESS A god on Earth thou art. (R2, 5.3.92-143)

The Duchess’ audacity to not only interrupt the king’s business, but to ignore his direct command is played comedically in the play, but speaks loudly to her character. She rejects the quiet, invisible mother standard, and instead makes herself impossible to ignore. Her use of finishing Bolingbroke’s lines or twisting them into couplets further cements her into the meter, unable to be ignored or removed.

Additionally, her description of herself as Bolingbroke’s wet-nurse is powerful in this appeal. This affair parallels Act 1, where Bolingbroke was banished for subtly criticizing Richard (1.1.1.06) and potentially starting a civil war (1.3.128-143). Bolingbroke’s father begs in vain for

a shorter sentence, and this father-son relationship motivates Bolingbroke through his campaign to receive his rightful inheritance. Consequently, the Duchess' use of familial language and describing herself as Bolingbroke's mother/wet-nurse reminds Bolingbroke that overstrict punishments can destroy a family's trust in the king and restart the cycle that got Richard deposed, so Bolingbroke decides to be lenient with Aurmele.

Both the Queen and the Duchess utilize the language of motherhood—especially conception, childbirth and nursing—to support their arguments against men. Crucially, this language cancels out their very socially unacceptable choices of not having children and supporting treason, respectively. The deliberate reminder that a woman, not soil, produces heirs, and as such women need to be respected, makes the men more amenable to their arguments, even when the woman isn't a mother. Further analysis of motherhood in the *Henriad* could follow Doll Tearsheet, who lives in a starkly different world than these noblewomen and wields her potential pregnancy as a weapon. Additionally, it could connect Richard's Queen to Queen Elizabeth I, and explore how Shakespeare incorporated modern politics into the character. Every father-son pair in the *Henriad* has a corresponding mother, typically unseen. The Queen of England and the Duchess of York refuse to stay buried.

Works Cited

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